

They are lying to you about weight loss.

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Aug 16, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/shorts/oCgCXqIYv8U> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

A 500-calorie deficit sounds simple but is too easy to accidentally blow. Brandon Carter offers a more reliable formula — bodyweight × 10 for calories and 1g protein per pound — exploiting protein's high thermogenic effect as a fat-loss "cheat code."

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Why the 500-Calorie Deficit Advice Fails [0:00](#)

- The mainstream influencer recommendation is a **500-calorie deficit** per day
 - Carter acknowledges this is technically true, but distinguishes between "what works" and "what's optimal"
- Food label inaccuracy is a major hidden problem
 - The FDA allows food labels to be off by **20% in either direction**
 - A food you believe is 500 calories could legally contain up to **600 calories**
 - This error can compound multiple times per day across multiple meals
- Untracked calories (e.g., condiments and sauces) add up fast
 - Sauces and condiments alone can contribute **hundreds of calories** that people routinely ignore
- Net result: a 500-calorie target margin is far too slim to survive real-world tracking errors

The Better Calorie Formula [0:22](#)

- Carter's recommended daily calorie target: **bodyweight (lbs) × 10**
 - This creates a larger, more forgiving deficit that absorbs tracking errors
- Protein target: **1 gram per pound of current bodyweight** (not goal bodyweight)
 - Emphasis on **current** bodyweight — a deliberate distinction from common advice to use goal weight

Protein as a Fat-Loss Cheat Code [0:45](#)

- Protein has the **highest thermogenic effect** of any macronutrient
 - Your body burns approximately **20% of protein's calories** just through the digestion process itself
 - Net absorption from protein is only **70–80% of listed calories**
- Comparison to other macronutrients:

Macronutrient	Thermogenic Effect (relative)
Protein	Highest (baseline)
Carbohydrates	~½ of protein's effect
Fat	~⅓ of protein's effect

- Common muscle-building advice says 1g/lb protein is enough to build muscle — Carter agrees, but says that's not the only reason to eat that much

"Protein is a cheat code. You don't absorb all of it because it takes so many calories for your body to digest."

- The practical implication: high protein intake effectively reduces your net calorie absorption, making it a built-in advantage for fat loss beyond just preserving muscle